curious way a mix of western liberal tradition with an Asian culture but an Asian culture which is different from other Asian cultures.[13]

Ideological and strategic renaissance

Whether Indian soft power is unique, the Indian government's growing attention to the concept mirrors the flourishing research on culture and identity in international relations since the 1990s, for example, to explain the lack of balancing against China in the East Asian order.[14] As a diplomatic strategy, the focus on soft power seeks to increase a country's foreign policy influence by shaping values, preferences, and perceptions in other countries. Scholars have argued either for the utility or futility of soft power with recourse to a variety of historical, country, and sectoral case studies.[15]

Initially defined by Joseph Nye, the concept suggests that the "proof of power lies not in resources but in the ability to change the behavior of states."[16] More specifically, soft power reflects a country's "ability to affect others to obtain the outcomes one wants through attraction rather than coercion or payment."[17] As one study points out, "a prime example of 'soft power', or the ability to persuade through culture, values and ideas," cultural diplomacy plays a key role in this strategy.[18] Naren Chitty notes that by activating the country's cultural heritage, "the soft power of archeological or historical objects may be re-politicized, and activated by influentials" and "long-forgotten narratives may be 'discovered' by and politicized by cultural entrepreneurs and political brokers, respectively."[19]

The case of India has attracted growing attention, with several in-depth studies on how governments have invested